



Surging ahead :
Kimi Antonelli and Mercedes lead the standings, with Ferrari in pursuit. Defending champion Lando Norris, fresh off a Sprint win, finished second in the latest race. REUTERS



Pics: AFP

MotoGP



Aprilia and Marco Bezzecchi's winning start to the 2026 season was eventually brought to a halt by a Marquez (not the expected one). It was Gresini Racing's Álex Márquez (**above**) who handed Ducati its first win of the season in the fourth race at Jerez. The victory came exactly a year after his maiden premier-class win at the same circuit, in a season where he finished runner-up to his elder brother Marc in the riders' championship.

Despite winning the Sprint and leading into Turn 1, Marc was overtaken by Álex on the second lap. A mistake at Turn 11 and the ensuing fall ended the defending champion's hopes of a first win of the season and opened the door for Aprilia. But its battle with VR46 Racing's Fabio Di Giannantonio for the podium allowed Álex to stretch his lead. He eventually finished nearly two seconds clear of the lead Aprilia. Diggia managed to pip former world champion Jorge Martín for third. Bezzecchi now leads teammate Martin by 11 points in the riders' standings.

